

Butterfly

A fluttering adult butterfly looks nothing like the crawling caterpillar it once was when it was young. That's because it has undergone a dramatic life change called complete metamorphosis. Like other insects that go through this transformation, the monarch butterfly, shown here, has four life stages: egg, larva, pupa, and adult.

Caterpillar

The caterpillars of the monarch butterfly munch milkweed leaves—the only plant they are able to eat.

To grow, a caterpillar must shed its skin. The old skin splits, and the caterpillar wriggles out, dressed in a new layer.

Caterpillars snip leaves with their scissorlike jaws.

Each caterpillar hangs in a J shape by a silk thread.

The tiny, wingless caterpillars crawl on stumpy legs.

Chrysalis

After about two weeks, a monarch caterpillar is fully grown. It sheds its skin for the fifth and final time before the caterpillar turns into a hanging chrysalis. The chrysalis is a kind of pupa: a pod inside which a crawling larva turns into a flying insect.

At first, the wings are crumpled and wet.

Eggs hatching

Monarch eggs hatch a few days after being laid. The larvae, called caterpillars, are so small they can barely be seen. They eat their eggshells and then start to feed on milkweed.

See also

You can also read about metamorphosis in ants (78–79) and dragonflies (82–83).